

Family Engagement Pack

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY

1



Lock It

PASSWORDS AND ACCOUNTS

2



Spot It

SCAMS AND FAKES

3



Share Smart

PRIVACY

4



Safe People

WHO TO TRUST

5



Kind and Well

KINDNESS AND BALANCE

6



Fix It

TELL, REPAIR, RECOVER

PLATE I. The six strands, hand-linked, in the order the lessons take them.

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OCTOBER 2026

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Hackles, Stage 7. Everything in this pack is written to be copied, filled in and sent home. Fields in [brackets] are yours to complete.

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4. Conversation starters (10 per grade band)
5. Family Tech Agreement template
6. Family Code Word guide
7. Family Reply slip template
8. Plain-language glossary
9. "What to do if your child tells you something scary" (one-pager)
10. Spanish-translation-ready note
11. Why we say trust your hackles (parent explainer)
12. Plus-lesson family cards (6-8 P1 to P3; 9-12 P1 to P4)

TO VERIFY

Consult counsel and policy. Parent notification and opt-out requirements vary by state and district. Have your administrator approve letters before sending. Statistics and legal references marked [VERIFY] should be confirmed with primary sources before printing.

01 **How to use this pack**

The two-way loop. Most school programs send a letter home and stop there. This kit sends a **take-home card** out with each lesson and gets a **Family Reply slip** back, so families can tell you what they tried, what questions they have, and what help they'd like. The reply slip is optional and never graded.

Principles for talking with families

- **Partners, not problems.** Assume every family cares deeply about their child's safety.
- **No blame, no fear.** Leave out the alarming statistics and the scary stories. Describe the skills and what children will practice.
- **Plain language.** Short sentences, no jargon. If you need a technical word, put it in the glossary.
- **Multiple formats.** Paper, email, text or a phone call, whichever the family prefers.
- **Language access.** Send materials in each family's home language where you can (see Section 10).
- **Every family is different.** Say "grown-up you trust" or "caregiver," and don't assume anything about family structure, devices or income.

Suggested schedule

WHEN	WHAT TO SEND
Start of the program	Letter A (general introduction)
2 weeks before a sensitive lesson	Letter B (pre-notice) with the opt-out and review form
After each lesson	One-line take-home card and Family Reply slip
After Lesson 1 of each band	Family Code Word guide (especially for grades 3-5)
Mid-year	Family Tech Agreement and conversation starters
After the program	Impact summary and thank-you

02 Take-home letter A: General introduction

FIELD NOTE

No. 1

[School letterhead]

[Date]

Dear families and caregivers,

This year, [Class/Grade] will take part in **Hackles**, a short weekly program that helps children stay safe, kind, and confident online. Each lesson takes about 15 minutes, and children spend that time practicing skills, with no scary stories anywhere in sight.

What your child will learn

- How to keep accounts and devices private and protected.
- How to spot tricks, scams, and fake pictures or voices.
- How to think about what to share online.
- How to recognize when someone is not being safe or kind.
- How to tell a trusted adult. This is the most important skill, and we practice it often.

Our habit: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.

- **Hackles up?** Notice the "uh-oh" feeling: something seems too good, pushy, secret, or scary.
- **Pause.** Stop and take a breath before clicking, replying, or sending.
- **Check.** Ask: Is this real? Who is this?
- **Tell.** Tell a trusted adult. Telling is never getting in trouble.

What we ask of you

- Talk with your child about what they're learning. Each lesson comes with a take-home card and a question to try at home.
- Fill in the optional **Family Reply** slip and send it back. It tells us what worked and what questions you have.
- Let your child know they can always come to you, and that they won't be punished for telling.

What this program does not do

- It does not collect student accounts or personal data.
- It does not teach children how to attack or break into systems.
- It does not replace your family's values, rules, or conversations.

A few lessons cover more sensitive topics. Before those, we'll send you a note, along with a way to review the materials or ask questions.

If you have questions, please contact [Teacher name] at [email/phone] or our school counselor, [Name], at [email/phone].

Thank you for being our partner in this.

[Teacher name], [Title]

[Translation note: this letter is translation-ready; see Section 10.]

03 Take-home letter B: Sensitive-topic pre-notice

FIELD NOTE

No. 2

[School letterhead]

[Date]

Dear families and caregivers,

On **[date]**, our class will have a Hackles lesson called "**[Lesson title]**." We're writing ahead of time because this lesson covers a more sensitive topic.

What the lesson is about

[Choose one and edit.]

- *K-2, My Body Is Mine*: Children learn that their bodies belong to them, that no one needs pictures of their body, and that they should tell a grown-up if anyone asks. The language is simple and not graphic.
- *3-5, Game Chat Red Flags*: Children learn warning signs when someone in a game or chat asks for secrets, gifts, or to move to another app, and practice saying "no" and telling a trusted adult.
- *6-8, Grooming Patterns / Pressure Online / Fakes That Hurt*: Students learn to recognize when someone online is building trust in unsafe ways, pressuring for pictures, or making fake images, and practice a response plan: STOP, SAVE, TELL, REPORT. The lesson is not graphic.
- *9-12, Sextortion and Image Abuse / Coercion in Relationships Online*: Students learn how threats and pressure can happen online, that it is never the victim's fault, and how to get help and report. The lesson is not graphic.
- *Plus lessons on trafficking and exploitation (6-8 P1, "Work, Pressure and Promises Online"; 9-12 P1, "Recruitment Online")*: Students learn the warning signs of a risky online offer or relationship (secrecy, deals that are too good, pressure to go private, debt, someone holding money, phone or papers) and who to tell. Everything is made up. Nobody acts out a victim or a recruiter. The lesson contains no explicit content and no description of what happens to victims.
- *Plus lessons on mental health and compulsive use (6-8 P2, "Scroll Science"; 9-12 P2, "Mind, Mood, and the Scroll")*: Students learn what researchers know and do not yet know about social media, sleep, mood and friendships, how to notice signals, and how to try a small reset and tell someone. Students are never asked to share their own screen time or feelings.

What the lesson does not include: graphic images or descriptions, or instructions for harming anyone.

Why we teach it: Children are safer when they have clear words to use, know that telling is safe, and know who to tell. Research on prevention suggests that practicing skills works better than warnings alone [VERIFY].

What support is available

- Our school counselor, [Name], will be available on the day of the lesson.

- Children may take a break, draw instead of discuss, or ask to speak with the counselor.
- Nobody is asked to share personal experiences in front of the class.

Your options

- **Review the materials.** You are welcome to preview the lesson. Contact [Teacher] by [date], or visit [time/place].
- **Opt out.** If you prefer that your child not take part, complete the attached form. Your child will do a respectful alternative activity, and their grades will not be affected. We will still make sure your child knows who to tell if something worries them.
- **Talk at home.** The take-home card will arrive after the lesson with questions you can use.

If you'd like to talk about this, please contact [Teacher name] at [email/phone] or [Counselor name] at [email/phone]. We're happy to answer questions, and we can arrange an interpreter.

Thank you,

[Teacher name], [Title]

Please return the form below by [date] if you would like to review or opt out. If we do not hear from you, your child will take part. [Edit to match your policy.]

✂ -----

Student: _____ Lesson: _____ Date: _____

- ☐ I would like to review the materials. Contact me at: _____
- ☐ I would like my child to do an alternative activity for this lesson.
- ☐ I have no concerns.

Signature: _____ Preferred language: _____

04 Conversation starters (10 per grade band)

A few tips before you start:

- Pick one question at a time, in a relaxed moment: a walk, a car ride, cooking, bedtime.
- Listen more than you talk. "Tell me more" does a lot of work.
- If your child shares a mistake, begin with "Thank you for telling me."
- You don't need to know the answer, and "Let's figure it out together" is a perfectly good thing to say, even when the question is about an app you've never heard of.
- No device needed.

K-2 (AGES 5-7)

1. Who are three grown-ups you could tell if something felt yucky or scary?
2. What is a secret you should always keep, and a secret you should tell?
3. Why do we keep our passwords secret, even from friends?
4. What would you do if a pop-up said you won something? Where in your body would you feel your hackles go up (tummy, neck, hands)?
5. What is the Oops Button, and what do you do when you press it?
6. What is something kind you could say online or in a game?
7. Can you show me how you say "I need help"?
8. How can you tell if a picture is real or pretend?
9. What makes your body yours? Who can you tell if someone asks you for a picture?
10. What is your favorite thing to do when you take a screen break?

3-5 (AGES 8-10)

1. What are the three rungs of the Help Ladder?
2. What makes a good, strong passphrase?
3. Have you seen an offer that seemed too good to be true? What gave it away?
4. What are some red flags in a game chat? What does it feel like when your hackles go up?
5. What would you do if someone in a game asked you to move to another app?
6. What are some ways to be an upstander when someone is being treated unkindly?
7. How can you tell if a picture, voice, or chatbot is real or made by AI?

8. What would be a good family code word? When would we use it?
9. If you clicked something by mistake, what would be your first step?
10. What is one thing you would want me to know about your online world?

6-8 (AGES 11-13)

1. What does "Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell." look like for you in a group chat?
2. If a friend told you a secret that worried you, what would you do? Did your hackles go up?
3. What are some signs that someone online is not who they say they are?
4. Which of your accounts would be hardest to lose? How do you protect it?
5. Have you seen a fake picture or video? How did you find out it was fake?
6. How do AI chatbots help you, and where are they not good enough?
7. If someone online pressured you for a picture, what would you do first? Who would you tell?
8. What would make it easier to tell me about something hard online?
9. What is one app setting you could check together with me?
10. How do you know when it is time to take a break from your phone or game?
11. (Plus lessons) If an online offer asked you to keep it secret, or to hand over something like your ID, who would you tell?
12. (Plus lessons) How can you tell whether a post is solid or just going around? What do you ask first?

9-12 (AGES 14-18)

1. What would your digital defense plan look like if you had to protect your most important accounts?
2. Which accounts have two-step verification or a passkey? Which do not?
3. What is a pattern you would notice if someone was manipulating you or a friend online? What does your gut say first, and what do you do with it?
4. What is your plan if someone threatens to share a private picture, real or fake?
5. How do you decide if something you see online is true?
6. How do you handle it when a friend is struggling and asks you not to tell?
7. What do you think about how much data companies have about you?

8. What does respect and consent look like in online relationships?
9. What is one thing you would like adults to understand better about your online life?
10. If I made a mistake in how I reacted to something online, how would you want me to respond?
11. (Plus lessons) What makes a job offer or a new relationship online feel real and safe, and what would make you stop and ask someone?
12. (Plus lessons) Which feature of an app pulls on you most, and what setting could we change together?
13. (Plus lessons) What is the difference between mean and harmful online, and where would you report?

05 Family Tech Agreement template

This is a conversation, and it is no kind of punishment. A family tech agreement is a set of shared promises that everyone makes together, adults included. It works best when children help write it, when the rules fit your child's age, and when you come back to it often. Write your own, use this one, or skip any part that doesn't suit your family.

Three rules before you begin

1. **The most important promise:** *"If something goes wrong online, I can tell you, and I will not be punished for telling."* Adults and children both sign this one.
2. **Everyone participates.** Adults agree to model the habits they ask for.
3. **It can change.** Review it every few months, and as your child grows.

FIELD NOTE	No. 3
Our Family Tech Agreement Family: _____ Date: _____ Review date: _____	
1. Our promise about telling ☐ If something online worries, scares, or confuses us, we tell each other. ☐ Telling is never getting in trouble. We start with "Thank you for telling me." ☐ We decide on consequences for unsafe choices later, and calmly. Being tricked or pressured is never the child's fault.	
2. Our trusted people (if I cannot tell a parent or caregiver, I can tell): 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____	
3. Our devices - Where we use devices: _____ - Where devices rest at night: _____ - Times we put devices away (meals, bedtime): _____ - We agree adults can look at settings together with the child, not secretly. [Edit to fit your child's age.]	
4. Our accounts and passwords - Passwords are private. Our child shares them only with: _____ - We use long passphrases and two-step verification where we can. - We ask before downloading new apps or games.	
5. Our sharing - We ask before posting pictures of anyone. - We do not share our address, school, or schedule with people we only know online.	

- We keep location sharing off unless we agree otherwise.

6. Our kindness

- We are kind online. If someone is unkind, we save it, tell a trusted adult, and do not retaliate.
- We do not share or forward private pictures of anyone.

7. Our family code word

- Our code word is kept in a safe place. We use it to check any urgent message or call.

8. If we get stuck

- If our hackles go up, we pause, we check, and we tell.
- We will check in together every _____ (week, month).

9. Adult promises

- ☐ I will stay calm when you tell me something hard.
- ☐ I will ask before I check your device, and explain why.
- ☐ I will put my own device away at: _____
- ☐ I will learn about what you like to do online.

Signed: _____

If it isn't working. Rules that are too strict can make a child hide things. Rules that are too loose can leave a child on their own. Adjust and try again. If you're worried about your child's safety or well-being, talk to your school counselor or doctor.

06 Family Code Word guide

What it is. A family code word is a secret word or short phrase that only your family knows. Say someone calls, texts or sends a voice message claiming to be a family member in trouble. You ask for the code word. If they can't say it, you don't act on the request.

Why it helps. Here is the problem: scammers use fake voices (including AI-cloned voices copied from a short audio clip), fake texts and a sense of urgency to push families into sending money or information. The FTC warns about these family emergency scams [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: consumer.ftc.gov]. A code word gives you a calm way to check.

How to set one up (10 minutes at the kitchen table)

- **Step 1: Choose it together.** Pick a word or phrase that's easy to remember and hard to guess, which rules out pet names, street names, birthdays and anything that appears on social media. Two random words work well. "Purple kettle."
- **Step 2: Keep it private.** Don't post it, text it, or write it on a shared device. Tell only family members and a few trusted adults.
- **Step 3: Agree on when to use it.** Examples: a call or message saying someone is in trouble or needs money; an unfamiliar person who says they were sent to pick up a child; any message that says "don't tell anyone."
- **Step 4: Add a callback rule.** Even with the code word, hang up and call back on a number you already know. Never use the number the caller gives you.
- **Step 5: Practice.** Do one pretend call this week and let your child ask for the code word. Make it a game.
- **Step 6: Change it if it gets out.** If the word is shared, picked up by a stranger, or used by mistake, choose a new one.

What to say if you are being pressured. "I'll call you right back." "What is our code word?" "I'm going to check with [family member]." Anyone who is really your family will understand. Teach the whole family the phrase:

Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell. The code word is your "Check." Tell children, too, that a false alarm is welcome. If their hackles go up and it turns out to be nothing, they did exactly the right thing.

Red flags that mean hackles up, so pause

- Extreme urgency ("Right now!")
- Secrecy ("Don't tell anyone.")
- Unusual payment ("Gift cards," "wire money," "crypto," "payment apps")

- A voice that sounds like family but is on an unknown number

Not just for scams. A code word can also be a **safety signal** for children. If a child texts the code word, it means "Come get me now, no questions asked." Some families add a second word that means "I need to talk, but I'm not in danger." Decide this together, and promise that when the word is used, the adult responds calmly and without punishment.

Special situations

- **Shared custody or several households:** make sure all caregivers know the word.
- **Grandparents and older relatives:** emergency scams target them often. Include them in the practice.
- **Young children:** keep it simple, and focus on "Never go anywhere with someone who doesn't know our word."

FIELD NOTE	No. 4
Trust your hackles. If a child's hackles go up at a message or call that claims to be family, the code word is how they check. If a child uses the code word or says "my hackles are up," thank them every time.	

07 **Family Reply slip template**

Purpose: To close the loop. The reply slip tells the teacher what families tried, what questions they have, and what help they would like. It is **optional, never graded, and does not require a child's or family's personal information beyond what they choose to share.**

FIELD NOTE	No. 5
Hackles: Family Reply	
Student's first name (optional): _____ Date: _____	
This week's lesson: [Lesson title]	
We talked about it at home:	
☐ Yes, with the take-home card	
☐ Yes, in our own way	
☐ Not yet	
What worked or what my child said (optional):	

Something we would like to learn more about:	
☐ Passwords and accounts	
☐ Scams and fake messages	
☐ Privacy and posting	

- ☐ Online games and chat
- ☐ Bullying and unkind behavior
- ☐ Fake pictures and AI
- ☐ Pressure from people online
- ☐ Screen time and well-being
- ☐ Other: _____

I would like:

- ☐ A call or meeting with the teacher or counselor
- ☐ This information in a different language: _____
- ☐ A copy of the Family Tech Agreement or Code Word guide
- ☐ Nothing for now, thank you

Our family set up (check any):

- ☐ A family code word
- ☐ A family tech agreement
- ☐ A "no punishment for telling" promise

Thank you! You can return this slip in your child's folder, or send a note by [email/phone].

TEACHER TIPS

*for using Reply slips***

- Keep a simple tally of how many came back (for the Assessment Pack's class tally).
- Respond to any request for a call within two school days.
- Do not share individual slips with other families. Share only anonymous themes.
- If a slip mentions a safety concern, follow the Disclosure and Incident Guide.
- Thank every family who replies, with a short note or a kind word.

08 Plain-language glossary

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
Account	Your personal space on a website, game, or app, protected by a username and password.
AI (artificial intelligence)	Computer programs that can write, draw, talk, or make decisions in ways that seem human.
App	A program on a phone, tablet, or computer.
Block	Stopping a person from contacting you.
Chatbot	An AI program that writes replies like a person. It is not a person.
Cyberbullying	Being unkind, threatening, or humiliating someone using phones, games, or the internet.
Data	Information about you, such as your name, location, interests, or what you click.
Deepfake	A fake picture, video, or voice made with AI to look or sound real.
DM (direct message)	A private message between people in an app.
Digital footprint	The trail of information about you that is left online.
Group chat	A shared chat with several people.
Grooming	When someone builds trust with a child in order to harm them later. It often includes secrecy, gifts, flattery, and isolation.
Help Ladder	The kit's plan for who to tell: a friend you trust, then a trusted adult, then a report. If one person does not help, keep climbing until someone does. (You may also see it called the "Tell-Someone Ladder" in older copies. Younger children practice a picture version called "My Tell-Someone Team.")
Location sharing	A setting that lets an app or other people see where you are.
Passkey	A modern way to log in without a password, using your device's fingerprint, face, or PIN.
Passphrase	A long password made of several random words.
Password manager	A tool that stores and creates strong passwords.
Phishing	A message or fake website that tries to trick you into giving information or money.
Privacy settings	Controls that decide who can see your information or contact you.
Report	Telling an app or the authorities about harmful content or behavior.
Scam	A trick to take your money or information.
Screenshot	A picture of what is on a screen.
Sextortion	When someone threatens to share a private or fake image unless a person sends money or more images. The person who threatens is responsible, never the child.
Take It Down	A free service from NCMEC that helps remove or stop the spread of images of people who were under 18 when the image was made [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: takeitdown.ncmec.org].
Trusted adult	A grown-up a child can tell about anything, such as a family member, teacher, counselor, or coach.

WORD	WHAT IT MEANS
Two-step verification	A second step, such as a code sent to your phone, that protects an account even if the password is stolen.
Upstander	Someone who helps when another person is being treated unkindly.
VPN	A tool that hides some information about your internet connection. It does not make you safe by itself.

09 One-pager: What to do if your child tells you something scary

FIELD NOTE

No. 6

If your child tells you something scary online: Your first minutes matter.

Children often wait to tell because they fear being blamed, punished, or losing their device. What you do in the first minutes can decide whether they tell you the rest.

1. Stay calm. Breathe. Keep your voice and face gentle. Your child needs you steady more than they need answers.

2. Say these words.

- "Thank you for telling me."
- "I'm glad you told me."
- "This is not your fault."
- "You are not in trouble."
- "We will get through this together."

3. Listen. Let them talk. Ask "Tell me more." Do not interrogate or ask "Why did you...?"

4. Do not blame or punish. Not now. Not for telling. Not for being tricked.

5. If it involves a picture or video of your child

- **Do not** look through it, share it, copy it, or forward it. Do not ask your child to show you again.
- **Do not** delete the account or messages yet. Keep the account name, links, and dates.
- **Do not** pay. Do not send more. Stop replying.
- **Do** screenshot text threats, usernames, and profile links if you can do so without capturing images. If unsure, wait for guidance.

6. Report and get help

- **NCMEC CyberTipline:** report.cybertip.org or 1-800-843-5678 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: report.cybertip.org]
- **Take It Down** (free image removal for people under 18 at the time): takeitdown.ncmec.org [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: takeitdown.ncmec.org]
- **Local law enforcement, or FBI:** tips.fbi.gov [VERIFY]
- **The platform:** use its report or block tools after evidence is saved.
- **Your child's school counselor or teacher:** they can help and support your child.
- **Child abuse hotline (Childhelp):** 1-800-422-4453 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: childhelphotline.org]

7. Watch for signs your child is struggling. If your child seems hopeless, says they want to hurt themselves, or cannot stop

crying, stay with them and call or text **988** (Suicide and Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: official sites of the named services]. You can also text HOME to 741741 [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: crisistextline.org].

8. Take care of yourself too. You may feel angry, scared, or ashamed. That's normal. Talk with someone you trust.

9. Keep the door open. Check in gently over the next days, and plan the next steps together. Review privacy settings, and think about a family tech agreement later, when things have calmed down.

10. Remember: The person who threatens, tricks, or harms is responsible. Your child is not.

Phone numbers and web addresses change. Please confirm them before relying on this page.

10 Spanish-translation-ready note

For the school or translator. Every letter, slip and page in this pack is written so it can be translated into Spanish (and other languages) with little change, and the suggestions below are there to protect the meaning and keep the tone warm, which matters more than a word-for-word match.

Recommended process

1. **Use a qualified translator** or your district's language access office. Avoid relying on unreviewed machine translation for sensitive-topic letters, the scary one-pager, or the glossary. [VERIFY your district's language access policy; consult counsel on notice obligations]
2. **Back-translate** sensitive texts: have a second person translate the Spanish version back into English to check for meaning.
3. **Test with a family.** Ask a Spanish-speaking parent or community liaison to read it and tell you if it sounds natural and respectful.
4. **Use the same layout** and keep the English version available alongside.
5. **Offer interpreters** for calls and meetings, and do not use children as interpreters.

Writing choices that help translation

- Sentences are short. Idioms are avoided.
- The words "grown-up you trust" can be translated as *adulto de confianza*.
- "Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell." can be translated; for the three action words use *Para*, *Comprueba*, *Cuenta* or *Pausa*, *Verifica*, *Avisa*, and translate "Hackles up?" as a short phrase about the uh-oh feeling. Choose the version your community prefers and use it consistently across all materials. [Translator to confirm]
- "Family code word" can be *palabra clave familiar* or *palabra secreta de la familia*. [Translator to confirm]

Terms that need care (translators, please choose with a community liaison)

ENGLISH	WHY IT NEEDS CARE
Sextortion	Often has no common everyday word. Use a descriptive phrase such as "threatening someone to share private pictures unless they send money or more pictures."
Grooming	May be mistaken for personal hygiene. Use a descriptive phrase such as "when someone builds trust to harm a child."
Cyberbullying	Commonly translated as <i>ciberacoso</i> or <i>ciberbullying</i> ; confirm with your community.
Deepfake	Many Spanish speakers say <i>deepfake</i> ; add a short explanation.
Screenshot	Often <i>captura de pantalla</i> ; some say <i>screenshot</i> . Use both once.

ENGLISH	WHY IT NEEDS CARE
Block, Report	Match the words used in the apps your families use.
Take It Down, NCMEC, CyberTipline	Keep names in English. NCMEC offers services in Spanish. [VERIFY]

Regional differences. Spanish varies by country. Ask your families which terms feel natural, and steer clear of forms that are too formal or too local.

Other languages. The same process applies. Keep a master glossary for each language and reuse it across materials.

Phone numbers. Check whether helplines offer Spanish or other languages, and add them to the translated pages. [VERIFY]

Tone. Keep the warm, non-blaming voice. If a phrase comes out sounding accusatory or fearful in translation, adjust it.

This pack is general guidance, not legal advice. Consult counsel and district policy on family notification, language access, and opt-out requirements.

11 Why we say "trust your hackles"

A parent and caregiver explainer. Copy it into a newsletter, send it home, or read it at a family night.

What are hackles? Hackles are what rise on the back of your neck when something feels off. Our program uses the word as a friendly name for that "uh-oh" feeling. Our mascot, Hackle, has orange spikes that stand up when something isn't right.

Why it matters. Children often feel that something is wrong long before they can say why. It might be a message that's too good to be true, a stranger who is oddly pushy, a request to keep a secret, or a picture or link that feels scary. Many of them ignore the feeling because they don't want to cause trouble, or because the person seemed nice. We teach children that the feeling is useful information, and that they can do something about it.

The habit: Hackles up? Pause. Check. Tell.

1. **Hackles up?** Notice the feeling. Something seems odd, too good, pushy, secret, or scary.
2. **Pause.** Stop. Do nothing yet. No clicking, replying, paying or sending.
3. **Check.** Is this real? Who is it from? What do they want?
4. **Tell.** Tell a trusted adult, every time, with no shame.

What "trust your hackles" does not mean.

- It doesn't mean your child must always be right. A false alarm is fine and welcome. A child who says "my hackles went up, and it was nothing" did the right thing.
- It doesn't make your child responsible for stopping every trick. If hackles were ignored, or your child was tricked anyway, **it is never their fault. Please help them tell someone.** Scammers and people who harm children are skilled at making things feel normal, which is exactly why a child can miss the signs and still have done nothing wrong.
- It is no reason to be afraid. We teach skills. Fear isn't part of it.

How you can help at home

- Ask: "Have your hackles ever gone up online? What did it feel like?" Then listen before you advise.
- Use the words yourself: "My hackles went up at that text. Let's pause and check."
- Stay calm when your child tells you something. The first reaction teaches them whether it's safe to tell you next time, so start with "Thank you for telling me."

- Try the hand signal together: hand raised and brushed up the back of the neck for Hackles up, then a flat Pause palm, Check eyes, and a Tell wave.

If something serious happens, see the one-pager in Section 9 and contact your child's school.

Hackles collects no student accounts and no student data, ever.

12 Plus-lesson family cards

SEND ONE CARD HOME after each Plus lesson, to every family including families who opted out. Reply slips are optional, and any format is fine. Offer cards in home languages [VERIFY translations by a qualified translator; do not machine-translate crisis information without review]. All hotline numbers below were read on 2026-10-05 and must be checked again within 14 days of printing.

Grades 6-8, P1: Work, Pressure and Promises Online.

Today in class students learned to spot warning signs in risky online offers: secrets, deals that are too good, a push to move to a private chat, "you owe me," being cut off from family, and someone holding your money or phone. They practiced saying, for a friend, "I need help with something online." At home you might ask: "If someone online offered you something and said not to tell anyone, who would you tell?" If you ever suspect trafficking or abuse, call the Florida Human Trafficking Hotline at 1-855-FLA-SAFE or the Florida Abuse Hotline at 1-800-962-2873. In danger now: 911. The school counselor is also available. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: fdle.state.fl.us; myflfamilies.com]

Grades 6-8, P2: Scroll Science.

Today in class we talked about how social media can affect sleep, mood and friendships, and what scientists know and do not know yet. Students practiced noticing signals and picking one "reset." At home, try: "What feels good about your apps, and what feels hard?" Consider keeping devices out of bedrooms overnight. If your child seems very down, anxious, withdrawn or hopeless, the school counselor can help, and 988 is available any time by call or text. Please talk with your child's doctor or a counselor if you are worried. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: 988lifeline.org]

Grades 6-8, P3: Fact, Fiction or Fake?

Today in class students played a "forward chain" game to see how a message changes when it is passed along, and practiced four questions before sharing: Who made it? What is the proof? Who else says so? How is it trying to make me feel? At home, try the questions on one post together. If a post is hurting someone or asking for money or personal information, report it in the app and tell a trusted adult.

Grades 9-12, P1: Recruitment Online.

Today your teen practiced spotting a pattern in made-up online messages: an opportunity or relationship (HOOK), a push to go private (MOVE), secrecy, debt or shame (BIND), and someone controlling money, phone, documents or contact (CONTROL). Ask your teen: "If an offer asked me to keep a secret or hand over my ID, what would I do?" To report suspected trafficking in Florida: 1-855-FLA-SAFE (1-855-352-7233). National Human Trafficking Hotline: 1-888-373-7888. Florida Abuse Hotline: 1-800-962-2873. In danger: 911. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: fdle.state.fl.us; humantraffickinghotline.org; myflfamilies.com]

Grades 9-12, P2: Mind, Mood, and the Scroll.

Today your teen mapped how social media can affect sleep, mood, relationships and attention, and chose one small adjustment to try for two weeks. At home: "Which app is hardest for you to put down? What would help?" Consider a shared rule about devices at night. If your teen seems down, withdrawn or hopeless, please involve the school counselor or your doctor. 988 (call or text) is available any time. [VERIFIED 2026-10-05: 988lifeline.org]

Grades 9-12, P3: Whose Goal Is It?

Today your teen studied how apps use endless scrolling, autoplay, notifications, reaction counts and recommendations, and chose two settings to change. At home: "Which of these pulls on you most? What setting could we change together?" Consider talking about notification times and device-free hours. If your teen seems low, anxious or unable to stop, the school counselor can help.

Grades 9-12, P4: From Mean to Harmful.

Today your teen learned four questions to tell mean from harmful online (Repeated? Hurtful? Public or hidden? Power?) and practiced what to do: do not retaliate, save words and usernames, block, report, support, tell. The state guide suggests saving evidence. If it is a nude or sexual picture of a young person, do not save or send it; tell a trusted adult. [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] If your teen is being targeted, please contact the school counselor or an administrator; schools have a bullying and harassment reporting process. In danger: 911.

Reply slip (all Plus cards, optional):

- ☐ We talked about it.
- ☐ We would like more information or a conversation with the counselor.
- Preferred language for family messages: _____
- Student name (optional): _____ Date: _____

For trafficking and mental-health cards, send the pre-notice first. 6-8 P1 and 9-12 P1 need the sensitive-topic pre-notice (Letter B above, or the lesson's own letter in the Teacher Guide) at least 5 school days ahead with the opt-out. 6-8 P2 and 9-12 P2 need a family note ahead of time.